enjoyed because it meant I could learn about the human body in lectures and then go home at the weekend and discuss the subject on equal terms with my father, a medical doctor. I remember feeling very proud.

Even so, in February 2003, my university studies would have scored around four out of 10 on the excitement scale, while the 2003 ICC Cricket World Cup that was about to start in South Africa rated 9.5.

The telephone was ringing.

'Hello.'

'AB, it's Dave Nosworthy here. We would like you to play for the Titans against Canada on Tuesday, 4 February, at Centurion Park. It's a warm-up match for them before the World Cup.'

'Er ... sorry ... did you say play for the Titans?'

I was stunned. Dave had watched me play for Affies a few months earlier and been kind enough to encourage me, but I never expected a call from the Titans coach just a few weeks after leaving school.

Arriving at the stadium on the morning of the game, literally as a boy among men, it was good to see some familiar faces in the home dressing room. There was Jacques Rudolph, whose cricket bag I had carried when I arrived at Affies, and there was Martin van Jaarsveld, who had so often played garden cricket at our home in Warmbaths.

My excitement levels were raised even further when I saw the cameras and realised the match was being broadcast live on SuperSport, and it turned out to be a special day. I shared an opening stand of 105 with Jacques and then, batting with Martin, took the score to 223 before I was bowled by off-spinner John Davison for 109. The Titans eventually made 365 for two in 50 overs, and then dismissed Canada for 148.

To score a century on my Titans debut, live on television, was an exhilarating experience but I was brought down to earth the following Saturday when I was selected to play in the Tukkies 2nd team, not the 1st team ... the 2nd team. This seemed odd. I was bemused. One moment,